LAURA CLARKE ADMINISTRATIVE SERVICES

H-2B Process Guide and Toolkit

For Jamaicans looking for seasonal work in the United States. Keep this with your documents.

The one rule: Don't pay or send your passport until the Ministry of Labour and Social Security confirms the agency is licensed for H-2B. And no one can guarantee you a visa.

We do not recruit or place workers. We cannot get you a job or a visa, and nobody can guarantee one. This guide explains the process, and we help with the Jamaican documents you will need.

The 6 steps

1 **Get your documents ready**
Passport, TRN, NIS number, birth certificate, photos, résumé and references. See the checklist on the next page.

2 **Check the agency is licensed**
Confirm it with the Ministry of Labour and Social Security before you pay or send documents.

3 **Call two or three agencies**
Use the call script and ask the same questions each time, then compare.

4 **Apply and interview with the agency**
Agencies screen candidates and put them forward to U.S. employers. Treat it like a job interview.

5 **The employer applies for approval**
The U.S. employer files a petition to hire you. This takes months, and approval is not guaranteed.

6 **Visa interview and travel**
Once the petition is approved, you attend a visa interview at the U.S. Embassy in Kingston.

Timing matters. Employers typically file in early January for jobs starting in April, so October to December is the time to get your documents and agency calls done.

DOCUMENTS

Documents checklist

Being ready fast helps you stand out. Ask each agency for its exact list, but expect to need most of these. Tick them off as you go.

- [ ] **Valid passport:** check the expiry date now.
- [ ] **TRN:** your Taxpayer Registration Number. Free at the agency.
- [ ] **NIS number:** your National Insurance Scheme number. Free at the agency.
- [ ] **Birth certificate and photo ID:** a valid government-issued photo ID.
- [ ] **Police record:** ask the agency who it must be addressed to *before* you apply.
- [ ] **Passport-sized photos:** recent and identical.
- [ ] **Short résumé:** past jobs with dates, especially hotel, kitchen, cleaning or landscaping work.
- [ ] **Work references:** names and phone numbers of past employers.

Don't order your police record too early. A Jamaican police record is issued for **one named recipient** and cannot be reused for another. Find out exactly who the agency or Embassy wants it addressed to before you pay for one.

Keep clear photos or scans on your phone, but **do not send passport copies to anyone** until you have confirmed they are licensed.

THE AGENCY

Check the agency, then make your calls

Recruiting workers for overseas jobs without an active registration with the Ministry of Labour and Social Security is against Jamaican law. The Ministry's Employment Agencies Unit publishes a list of approved overseas job placement agencies. **Check that yours is approved for H-2B**, not only for another programme such as J-1. The list changes monthly, so always check the latest one.

Phone	876-676-5806 or 876-676-5748
WhatsApp	876-553-5457
Email	employmentagencyunitja@mlss.gov.jm
Address	1F North Street, Kingston

Ask: *"Is this agency currently licensed for H-2B?"* Write down the date and who you spoke to.

The Embassy checks your recruiter too. Since January 1, 2025, H-2B applicants must name their recruiting agency on the visa application. **If your recruiter is not registered, the application is rejected** and you must apply again through a registered one.

What to say on the phone

"Good morning. My name is _____. I am calling about H-2B work in the U.S. for the coming season. Are you taking applications, and how do I get an appointment or interview?"

8 questions to ask every agency

1. Is your Ministry licence current, and what is the licence number?

2. Which U.S. employers and industries do you work with?

3. What jobs, pay rates, locations and start dates are available?

4. What are your requirements (age, experience, documents)?

5. What fees, if any, do I pay, and when? Will I get a receipt?

6. Will I get a written contract or job offer before I pay or travel?

7. How long does the process take, and how will you keep me updated?

8. How many Jamaicans did you place last season?

Anyone can say yes to everything, so trust the written paperwork, not the promises. Under U.S. rules, H-2B employers and their recruiters may not charge workers a recruitment or placement fee. If an agency asks for any payment, ask the Employment Agencies Unit whether it is allowed **before you pay**, and always get a receipt.

TRACK YOUR CALLS

Call log

Write down every call. If you hear nothing for a week, follow up politely.

Date	Agency	Spoke to	Licence no.	What they said / fees	Follow up

Protect your money

Scam red-flag card

The U.S. Embassy in Kingston has warned that unregistered recruiters have a history of charging illegal fees and placing Jamaican workers at different worksites from the ones on their applications. Walk away if you see any of these.

X	A “guaranteed” visa or a paid “fast-track”
X	Cash payments with no receipt
X	Payments by WhatsApp or mobile money
X	No written contract or job offer
X	No licence number, or the Ministry cannot confirm it
X	Pressure to pay today
X	Jobs offered only on TikTok, Instagram or Facebook, with no named employer
X	Asking for your passport before anything has been checked

Be honest on every form. Lying or taking part in fraud can make you **permanently ineligible** for a U.S. visa. Your visa application also asks who recruited you, so the Embassy will see who you used.

The season at a glance

October to December	Get documents ready, check agencies, start calling
January	Employers typically file for April start dates
February to March	Interview preparation; the limit is often reached
April onwards	Late openings and any extra visas

Dates shift each year. The U.S. issues only 66,000 H-2B visas a year, and demand usually beats the limit. Confirm the current position on the USCIS website.

TIPS

How to improve your chances

No one can promise placement, but these habits help.

- Apply early, and to more than one licensed agency.
- Have your documents ready before your first appointment.
- Be easy to reach. Answer calls and reply the same day.
- Highlight relevant experience: hotel, kitchen, cleaning, landscaping or other physical work.
- Know your job details before the visa interview: the employer, location, pay and start date.
- At the Embassy, be ready to explain the job, how long you will stay, and the ties that bring you back to Jamaica when the season ends.
- If you are placed, work only for your employer and return on time. A clean record helps you be welcomed back.

The Ministry's own programme

The Ministry also runs its own Overseas Employment Programme. The Minister has said plainly that **there is no fee at any stage** of the Ministry's recruitment or placement. If someone using the Ministry's name asks you for any payment other than the visa fee at the end of the process, they are not authorised. Ask your Member of Parliament's constituency office how selection works in your area, or visit mlss.gov.jm.

Need your documents ready in time? We help with online passport renewals where PICA allows, police record applications (we complete the application, pay the fee and book your fingerprinting appointment), and certified birth certificate copies from the RGD. TRN and NIS are free at the agency. See documenthelpja.com or message us on WhatsApp.

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